MEANING AND CONCEPT

Both the terms ‘disarmament’ and ‘arms control’ might seem to be synonymous but there is a subtle line of difference between the two. **Disarmament** means the elimination or reduction of armaments to preserve international peace and security by averting wars. According to Morgenthau[1], “Disarmament is the reduction or elimination of certain or all armaments for the purpose of ending the armament race”. According to experts on disarmament and arms control like Charles P. Schleicher disarmament “means of reducing or eliminating the material and human instrumentalities for the exercise of physical violence”. According to an authority in international politics, like V.V. Dyke*, “Any regulation or limitation having to do with armed power is treated as a measure of Disarmament”.

Couloumbis and Wolfe[2], while showing the difference between disarmament and arms control, opine: “In its absolute sense disarmament requires the global destruction of weapons and the disestablishment of all armed forces”. Disarmament for them is quite inclusive and can mean anything from outlawing of all military arsenals and establishments to the banning of particular weapons in the interest of ‘humanization’ of war and even the implementation of specific agreements designed to prevent the accidental outbreak of war.

While complete disarmament may be difficult to achieve and in some sense is unattainable, the concept of **arms control** has crept in and has gained currency. Couloumbis and Wolfe[3] point out that, as chances of total disarmament become so minimal, its advocates are often regarded as utopians or propagandists and arms control becomes more relevant in the literature of international relations.

Arms control is a generic term and it normally includes two categories: arms reduction and arms limitation. Arms reduction stands for partial disarmament and it implies a mutually agreed-upon set of arms levels for the nation-states involved. The arms reduction formula may apply either to all states worldwide or to a small number of states on a regional basis. Arms limitation, on the other hand,